undisturbed until the recent big bang of modernity. In this view, people eventually died in their villages of birth. According to one historian in the 1960s, a village looked outside ‘for little more than its salt, its spices, the fine cloth for its holiday clothes, and the coin in which it pays its revenue’.[3] The idea of spatial mobility in Indian history was confined to the occasional pilgrim, merchant or warrior on a particular mission and little else.

This view of low spatial mobility in Indian history is seriously questionable. Not only has India witnessed some of the world’s largest episodes of voluntary and involuntary migration, but it is also unique in currently sustaining considerable immigration, internal migration and emigration—all three at the same time. A reading of Indian history, as shall be seen in this chapter, reveals that migrations, internal and external, and events before the late 19th century had already created a unique amalgamation of cultures that can be observed in India today. The past century and a half, however, was critical in reshaping existing diversities within, and more importantly, exporting these diversities outside the subcontinent, a fascinating phenomenon that informs the rest of this book. But we must begin by asking a more fundamental question: Who exactly are the Indians?

Brownian Motion

To depict an Indian as a brown-skinned human being with black eyes and black hair, like Apu in the animated American sitcom *The Simpsons*, would be accurate only as a crude average with large variations around the mean. Human beings are a colourful bunch of primates with interesting variations in the colour of skin, hair and eyes. Skin colour, for instance, has been found to be positively correlated with latitude and ultraviolet radiation levels, and has adapted over time to new environments.[4] Until we started decking up our bodies with clothes, human skin faced the full onslaught of penetrating solar rays and was a ripe candidate to undergo evolutionary change consistent with the Darwinian notion of natural selection. Some ultraviolet radiation, UV-B rays to be more precise, is good as it aids the